

Artis S880

This quad-channel speaker system features a black wooden finish and sports a very sophisticated workmanship. The subwoofer carries the controls for master volume, subwoofer volume and rear volume along with the power switch. The quick setup guide makes it very simple to install. It was



also one of the few speakers to bundle stands for the satellites making it very simple to place them around the listener for optimum surround imaging. At Rs

4,000, it strikes a good balance between price and audio performance. If you already have a four-channel soundcard or if you intend to buy one, this speaker is a good choice.

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Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶
Warranty & support	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶

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trol without any control for audio parameters such as bass and treble. The external amplifier also has buttons for choosing any one of the four preset sound equalization settings, namely rock, classic, jazz and pop. The front panel of the amplifier houses a 3.5 mm socket for connecting a pair of external earphones.

Nowadays, most of the manufacturers have started to provide speaker stands for satellites. The stands impart a good grip to the satellites and provide greater control over the positioning of the satellites. The only 5.1 speaker system that did not feature speaker stands was the Typhoon Acoustic 5.1.

Performance

The truest measure of a speaker's performance is the quality of its sound reproduction with different types of audio signals. Speakers with higher power ratings don't always translate into better sound. For a speaker system to sound good, it should be able to reproduce sounds across the audible frequency range with a flat (constant) response and with the lowest possible distortion across volume levels.

In-game sound quality: In the 2.1 speaker category, the Sumoku Alpha - 4R is a good choice if you like playing games at high volumes—it was very clear even when the volume was turned up to 80 per cent. This was a rare accomplishment compared to the rest of the 2.1 speakers. Also the mid-frequencies were especially well defined.



Speakers that do especially well in gaming audio are those that have a good transient response—this type of audio response occurs when there is an extreme change between sound signal levels delivered to the speaker as in the case of gunfire, explosions and thunder.

Other 2.1 speakers that did well here were the two Labtec speakers—the Pulse 424 and the Pulse 325. The only thing that gives the Labtec Pulse 424 an edge over its kin is the higher power rating for the subwoofer and satellites. When

running *Quake III Arena*, the Labtec Pulse 424 was able to output good treble effects and the bass delivered a well-rounded punch when played loud, especially during rocket launcher and machine gun skirmishes. The only problem with this speaker was that at very high volume levels, the treble and mid-ranges were distorted. Even at 50 per cent volume level we could hear a creaking sound from the subwoofer, though this is not loud enough to be immediately apparent. The Sumoku Alpha - 4R, the Labtec Pulse 325 and the Labtec Pulse 424 also sounded pretty good when playing *Serious Sam: Second Encounter*. The gunfire and the background audio track were very sharp even when playing at higher volume levels.

On to the 4.1 speaker systems, the in-game sound quality of the Logitech Soundman Xtrusio DSR 100 was commendable and this was apparent from the defined audio effects and in the reproduction of the background gaming music. Its 52 watt RMS subwoofer thumped with power while playing back the in-game audio effects. But the avid gamer who likes to play games at high volume levels might be disappointed because at higher volume the overall sound quality starts to drop considerably. The other speaker systems that did very well in this test were the Typhoon 5D, the Sumoku Alpha - 7 and the Artis S800.

The speaker that delivered sub-par performance was the Creative Inspire 4.1 4400—the in-game sound effects were not as immersive as the others in this test. This was apparent from the fact that it lacked the power to reproduce the effects of the machine gun fire and the faint echo that is heard when firing the rail gun in *Quake III*.

If you want to enjoy the full experience of a Dolby Digital encoded movie DVD and if you also want to be future-ready to play the next

generation of games that will support Dolby Digital audio, 5.1 speakers are the only way to go. Here the Artis X8 5.1 sneaks ahead of its partner, the Artis S5100, by a hair's breadth. But there is no question about the power and the sound quality of the Artis X8—while running *Serious Sam: SE*, one could feel the thunderous sound of the spacecraft exploding overhead in the map Sierra de Chiapas. As this game also supports EAX and Direct3D, the overall experience was nothing short of truly immersive! We couldn't wait to find out how a rocket in *Quake III* would sound. After firing up the game, the sound effects of the machine gun and rocket launcher firing was powerful and seemed to hit you right in your gut! The zing of the rail gun was reproduced perfectly, complete with the faint and distant echo that accompanies the firing of this weapon. The Artis S5100 came in a close second to the X8 in terms of overall gaming sound quality as its overall punch of the low frequencies was not as convincing as the X8. If you are heavily into playing games, both these speakers are good choices as they reproduce the audio effects well with the power and clarity that gaming demands.

The 5.1 speaker that trailed in this test was the Mercury SR-301 F; it lost out on fidelity at high volume.

